

Instructor Guide — Lesson 1: Your Professional Presence

Metadata

Field	Detail
Path	Digital Independence Path
Course	Course 18 — Professional Presence & Opportunity Building
Lesson	Lesson 1 of 8 — Your Professional Presence
Format	Live, instructor-led (video conference)
Age range	15–18
Duration	60 minutes
Group size	Up to 16 students recommended
Prerequisite	Course 16 (Portfolio Website) completed — every student must already have a working personal portfolio site
Tools referenced	LinkedIn (age-eligible students only), Canva, Google Docs, a content-planning tool (e.g., a simple spreadsheet or planner template)
Student materials	Student_Lesson.md, Worksheet.md

Overview

This lesson introduces "professional presence" as a broad concept — the sum of what a stranger, recruiter, mentor, or collaborator can find and conclude about a student when they look them up online. It is deliberately platform-agnostic: LinkedIn is one possible venue, not the definition. Students leave this lesson understanding two equally valid paths forward in this course:

- **Path A — LinkedIn-eligible path:** for students who meet LinkedIn's minimum age (currently 16) and any stricter local/consent requirement, and who choose to create a profile.
- **Path B — Portfolio-first path:** for students under the applicable age threshold, or who simply prefer not to use LinkedIn. This path builds a "presence page" on their existing Course 16 portfolio site, extended with the same substance a strong LinkedIn profile would have (bio, skills, projects, contact path) — without an account on a third-party platform.

Both paths are treated as equally credible in this course. No student is disadvantaged, and no student is ever told to misstate their age or work around a platform's age gate.

CRITICAL Compliance Note — Read Before Teaching

LinkedIn requires account holders to be at least 16 years old. This is LinkedIn's current stated minimum, and it is a floor, not a ceiling: some countries and regions set a higher minimum age, and some may require parental/guardian consent even above the platform minimum. Policies like this change, so:

- **Before class**, the instructor must independently verify LinkedIn's current age policy and any applicable local/regional age or consent requirements for the class roster's locations. Do not rely solely on this document or on prior cohorts' information — check LinkedIn's current terms/help center and any local guidance as of the day you teach this lesson.
- **In class**, state the rule plainly: LinkedIn is 16+, subject to local law that may set a higher age or require consent. Never present this as a suggestion — it is a hard eligibility rule.
- **Students below the applicable age must NOT create a LinkedIn account.** There is no workaround, no "just put a different birthdate," no exception. This must be said explicitly and without hedging.
- **The portfolio-first path is not a consolation prize.** Frame it as an equally credible, in some ways more flexible, professional presence — fully owned by the student, with no platform account required at all.

Prep (Before Class)

1. **Verify current LinkedIn age policy** (see above) and note today's date of verification in your lesson log.
2. **Determine eligibility per student** before class starts, using whatever age/consent information the program already holds on file (do not ask students to disclose age live in class beyond confirming their own path). Prepare a simple two-column roster: Path A (LinkedIn-eligible) / Path B (portfolio-first) so you can address each group directly.
3. Confirm every student's Course 16 portfolio site is live and reachable — this lesson depends on it for Path B and for the demo.
4. Prepare the live demo materials: a fictional student profile mockup (see Demo section) — do NOT use a real LinkedIn account or a real person's profile on screen.
5. Have Canva, Google Docs, and the content-planning template ready to screen-share.
6. Load Student_Lesson.md and Worksheet.md for reference during discussion.

Teaching Sequence

Time	Segment
0:00–0:05	Welcome, agenda, why this course exists (opportunity-building, not just "getting a job")
0:05–0:15	What is "professional presence"? Concept talking points
0:15–0:22	The LinkedIn age rule — stated plainly, no ambiguity
0:22–0:30	Two-path structure explained; students identify which path applies to them

Time	Segment
0:30–0:45	Live demo: comparing a LinkedIn profile view vs. a portfolio-first presence page (fictional student)
0:45–0:52	Discussion questions
0:52–0:57	Activity: self-assessment (Worksheet Part 1) started in class
0:57–1:00	Recap, common misconceptions correction, close, submission instructions

Talking Points: What "Professional Presence" Means

- Professional presence is **everything a person can discover about you that speaks to your skills, interests, and reliability** — not one profile, one post, or one platform.
- It includes: how your work is described, what projects you can show, how easy you are to find, how consistent your story is across places, and whether what's public represents you accurately and positively.
- It is built through **repetition and consistency over time**, not a single setup session. A presence made once and abandoned decays; one updated after each project or milestone compounds.
- Key framing: **"Presence compounds like a reputation does."** Every project you add, every skill you document, every clear explanation you write makes the next person's first impression better and faster to form — the effect stacks.
- It matters for far more than job-hunting: mentorship requests, competition team invitations, scholarship applications, and collaborators finding you all depend on discoverability.
- Two paths, one goal: by the end of Course 18, every student — regardless of path — will have a professional presence that credibly shows their skills, projects, and growth.

Talking Points: The Two-Path Structure

- **Path A (LinkedIn-eligible):** For students who meet LinkedIn's current minimum age (16+) and any stricter local/consent rule. They will build and maintain a LinkedIn profile across this course, in addition to keeping their portfolio site current.
- **Path B (portfolio-first):** For students who don't yet meet the applicable age/consent threshold, or who choose not to use LinkedIn. They will build a dedicated "presence page" on their existing portfolio site that does everything a strong LinkedIn profile does — headline, bio, skills, project showcase, and a way for people to reach them — without requiring any third-party account.
- State directly: **"If you're not old enough, or your family hasn't approved it, you do not create a LinkedIn account for this class. You will build an equally strong presence using your portfolio instead, and that is not a lesser option — it's a different, fully-owned option."**
- Every subsequent lesson in Course 18 will offer parallel instructions for both paths.

Live Demo: Comparing Two Presences (Fictional Student)

Use a fictional student, "Sam K.," for both mock-ups. Never use a real profile.

Mock-up 1 — LinkedIn profile view (built in Canva/slides, not a live account): - Headline: "Aspiring Software Developer | Python & Web Projects | Lumexa Student" - About section: 2–3 sentences on interests and current focus - Featured section: 2 project links with one-line descriptions - Skills: Python, HTML/CSS, teamwork, problem-solving

Mock-up 2 — Portfolio-first presence page (Sam's Course 16 site, new "Presence" page added): - Same headline styled as a page title - Same About text - A projects gallery with the same 2 projects, richer (screenshots, live links) - A "Skills & Growth" section - A simple contact form or email link — no third-party account needed

Talking point during demo: point out that the *content* is nearly identical — the difference is only the venue. This proves presence is about substance, not platform. Ask students: "What's actually different between these two? What's the same?" (Answer: contact mechanism and platform reach are different; substance, credibility, and effort are the same.)

Discussion Questions

1. If someone searched your name today, what would they find — and is that an accurate picture of you?
2. Why might a portfolio-first presence actually give you *more* control than a LinkedIn profile?
3. What's one project you've already done that deserves to be part of your professional presence?
4. How might your presence need to look different in two years vs. today? What stays constant?
5. Why do platforms set age minimums like LinkedIn's 16+, and why is it important to respect them rather than work around them?

Common Misconceptions to Correct

- **"I need LinkedIn to have a professional presence."** False — correct firmly: a portfolio-first presence is equally valid and, for this course, equally credited. LinkedIn is one venue among several, not a requirement.
- **"Presence just means being on one platform."** False — presence is the sum of everything discoverable about you (portfolio, projects, any profile, how you're described by others), not a single account.
- **"If I'm not old enough for LinkedIn, I'm behind."** False — reframe: portfolio-first students often build richer, more customized presences because they aren't constrained by a template.
- **"I'll just lie about my age to get an account."** Address directly and firmly: this is not permitted, not supported by the program, and not necessary — the portfolio-first path achieves the same goal without it.

Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Difficulty	Response
Student unsure which path applies to them	Instructor confirms using pre-class roster; never debate age eligibility live in front of the group — handle privately if needed

Difficulty	Response
Student on Path B feels their option is "worse"	Reinforce equal-credibility framing; show the demo comparison again
Portfolio site from Course 16 is broken/offline	Pair with a buddy or flag for a quick fix before Lesson 2; do not let this block today's conceptual work
Student wants to sign up for LinkedIn "just to see" during class	Redirect: no account creation happens live in class; eligibility must be confirmed first, and today is about concepts, not sign-ups
Student confuses "presence" with "having a resume"	Clarify: presence is broader and ongoing; a resume is one static document, presence is a living, discoverable footprint

How to Review Student Work

- Confirm each student completed Worksheet Part 1 (eligibility self-check) accurately and chose a path.
- Confirm the path chosen matches the instructor's pre-verified roster (flag any mismatch privately, never publicly).
- Check that the reflection response describes professional presence in the student's own words, not a copy of the lesson text.
- Check that the goals section names a concrete, specific goal for what their presence should look like by Lesson 8 (not a vague "look professional").

Lesson Close

- Recap: professional presence is broad, ongoing, and compounding — not one profile.
- Recap the age rule one more time, plainly: **LinkedIn is 16+, subject to stricter local/consent rules; below that, use portfolio-first — no exceptions.**
- Remind students both paths are graded and supported equally for the rest of Course 18.
- Assign: finish Worksheet.md (all three sections) before Lesson 2, and bring their portfolio site login/access.